

Stepping up: In the last few years, with G. Sathiyam struggling, Harmeet Desai has won some key matches in the team events. M. VEDHAN



rising pair of Ayhika Mukherjee and Sutirtha Mukherjee, is nothing short of remarkable.

Amid this success, the Indian women's stunning 3-2 victory over second-seed Korea was somewhat overshadowed. This victory came after World No. 90 Ayhika Mukherjee stunned World No. 9 Shin Yubin 3-2 in the opening clash and later secured the tie with a 3-1 win over Jeon Jihee.

It is worth remembering that at the World Championships earlier this year, Ayhika also stunned World No. 1 Sun Yingsha. Together, in the quarterfinals, World No. 15 pair of Ayhika and Sutirtha overcame Korea's Kim Nayeong and Lee Eunhye 3-1, ensuring a historic first bronze in the women's paired event. However, in the semifinals, the Japanese duo of Miwa Harimoto and Miyuu Kihara, the eventual silver medallists, proved too strong for the Indians.

Ayhika and Sutirtha, gradually gaining rankings and respect, announced their arrival by shocking Chinese World Champions and then World No. 2 Wang Yidi and Chen Meng in the quarterfinals of the Asian Games last year. This stunned the partisan home crowd in Hangzhou.

Following the Indian men's and women's teams qualifying for the Olympics for the first time in Paris this year, these twin-team medals reinforce the notion that the current crop of players has the potential to excel, particularly in team events.

Until 2018, India's triumphs

primarily came from the Commonwealth Games and the Commonwealth Championship, where the decline of Singapore, England, and Hong Kong coincided with the steady rise in India's performance levels.

The mixed doubles bronze for Sharath Kamal and Manika Batra in the 2018 Asian Games, the women's doubles bronze at the 2022 Asian Games, and the recent Asian bronze by the gallant Ayhika-Sutirtha duo have forced the competition to take India's challenge more seriously in paired events.

Team golds at the Commonwealth

« The UTT has been crucial in allowing Indian players to compete against top players across categories »